

Word family: **sugar-coat / sugarcoat / sugar-coated / sugarcoating / sugar-coating**

Base word: sugar-coat

Part of speech: mainly verb

Spelling note: **sugar-coat** and **sugarcoat** are both encountered. Dictionaries and style conventions vary on whether the compound is hyphenated or closed. Your passage uses **sugar-coat**, so I'll keep that form as the main one here.

Related forms:

sugar-coat / sugarcoat (v.) — 裹上糖衣；粉飾；把難聽的事說得好聽

sugar-coated / sugarcoated (adj.) — 裹糖衣的；經粉飾的；被美化的

sugar-coating / sugarcoating (n.) — 糖衣；粉飾；美化說法

sugar-coated pill — 糖衣藥丸；figuratively 「包裝得較易接受的壞消息 / 苦藥」

Useful expressions / extensions:

sugar-coat something

sugar-coat the truth

sugar-coat the facts

sugar-coat bad news

sugar-coat a problem

sugar-coat reality

don't sugar-coat it

there's no way to sugar-coat it

without sugar-coating it

a sugar-coated version

sugar-coated language

sugar-coating the truth

Meaning in this passage

> What I appreciated was that he did not try to **sugar-coat it** or make weak excuses.

Here, **sugar-coat it** is figurative.

It means:

make an unpleasant truth, mistake, or situation sound less bad than it really is — 粉飾；淡化；把難聽的事說得較好聽

Kevin did **not** try to soften his mistake with flattering language, vague wording, or excuses. He admitted directly that he had jumped to conclusions.

****中文翻譯：****

我很欣賞的一點是，他沒有試圖****粉飾 / 輕描淡寫自己的錯誤****，也沒有找一些無力的藉口。

So here:

****sugar-coat it = 把原本難聽、不愉快或令人難以接受的事實包裝得較好聽、較容易接受****

1. ****sugar-coat (literal : 裹上糖衣) — 裹上糖衣****

This is the original literal sense behind the metaphor.

Practice 1

> The tablets are ****sugar-coated**** to make them easier to swallow.

這些藥片外面****裹了一層糖衣****，令人較容易吞服。

Practice 2

> The nuts were ****sugar-coated****.

那些果仁外面****裹上了糖****。

Practice 3

> The manufacturer ****sugar-coated the medicine**** to improve the taste.

製造商在藥物外面****加上糖衣****來改善味道。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****sugar-coat = 在食物、藥片等表面加上一層糖或甜味外層****

2. ****sugar-coated (literal : 有糖衣的) — 裹糖衣的****

Practice 1

> These are ****sugar-coated tablets****.

這些是****糖衣藥片****。

Practice 2

> The snack consists of **sugar-coated nuts**.

這款小食由**裹糖果仁**製成。

MCQ-ready definition:

sugar-coated = 表面覆蓋着一層糖或甜味外層的

3. **sugar-coat something** (figurative : 粉飾 ; 美化) — 把事情說得較好聽

This is the major modern figurative sense and the one used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> He did not try to **sugar-coat it**.

他沒有試圖**粉飾這件事 / 把事情說得好聽一點**。

Practice 2

> There's no point trying to **sugar-coat the situation**.

沒有必要試圖**粉飾這個情況**。

Practice 3

> Don't **sugar-coat the problem**. Tell me what actually happened.

不要**淡化 / 粉飾問題**，直接告訴我究竟發生了甚麼。

MCQ-ready definition:

sugar-coat something = 用較悅耳、溫和或正面的方式描述不愉快的事，使它聽起來沒有那麼嚴重

4. **sugar-coat the truth** — 粉飾事實；把真相說得較好聽

Practice 1

> Don't **sugar-coat the truth** just to make me feel better.

不要只是為了讓我好受一點而**粉飾事實**。

Practice 2

> She refused to **sugar-coat the truth**.

她拒絕**把真相說得比較好聽**。

MCQ-ready definition:

sugar-coat the truth = 刻意用較溫和或討好的方式表達真相，使其不那麼難以接受

5. **sugar-coat the facts — 美化 / 淡化事實**

Practice 1

> The report should present the facts clearly rather than **sugar-coat them**.

報告應清楚呈現事實，而不是**粉飾事實**。

Practice 2

> He wasn't trying to **sugar-coat the facts**.

他沒有試圖**淡化事實的嚴重性**。

MCQ-ready definition:

sugar-coat the facts = 把客觀事實描述得比實際情況更正面或較不嚴重

6. **sugar-coat bad news — 把壞消息說得較容易接受**

Practice 1

> The manager tried to **sugar-coat the bad news**.

經理試圖把壞消息**說得沒那麼難聽**。

Practice 2

> There's no easy way to **sugar-coat this news**.

這個消息很難**包裝得好聽**。

MCQ-ready definition:

****sugar-coat bad news = 用較溫和、正面的表達方式傳達不好的消息****

7. ****sugar-coat a mistake / failure — 淡化錯誤 / 失敗****

Very relevant to your passage.

Practice 1

> He admitted his mistake instead of trying to ****sugar-coat it****.

他直接承認錯誤，而不是試圖****淡化自己的過失****。

Practice 2

> We shouldn't ****sugar-coat the failure****.

我們不應該****粉飾這次失敗****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****sugar-coat a mistake/failure = 避免直接承認其嚴重性，而用較好聽的方式描述****

8. ****sugar-coat reality — 美化現實；粉飾現實****

Practice 1

> The documentary doesn't ****sugar-coat reality****.

這套紀錄片沒有****美化現實****。

Practice 2

> There's no point ****sugar-coating reality****.

沒有必要****粉飾現實****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****sugar-coat reality = 把真實情況呈現得比實際更美好、更容易接受****

9. ****Don't sugar-coat it. — 不要粉飾；有話直說****

A very common conversational form.

Practice 1

> **Don't sugar-coat it.** Was my presentation bad?

**不用說得那麼好聽。我的簡報是不是很差？

Practice 2

> **Don't sugar-coat it**—just tell me the truth.

不要粉飾了，直接告訴我真相。

MCQ-ready definition:

Don't sugar-coat it = 不要為了令事情聽起來較好而淡化真相；直接說

10. **There's no way to sugar-coat it — 沒辦法把事情說得好聽**

A highly useful fixed pattern.

Practice 1

> **There's no way to sugar-coat it: we failed.**

**這件事沒辦法說得好聽：我們失敗了。*

Practice 2

> There's really **no way to sugar-coat the result**.

這個結果真的**無法美化**。

MCQ-ready definition:

there's no way to sugar-coat it = 情況非常明確或糟糕，無法透過委婉措辭掩飾

11. **without sugar-coating something — 不加粉飾地；直截了當地**

Practice 1

> Tell me what happened **without sugar-coating it**.

不要**粉飾**，直接告訴我發生了甚麼。

Practice 2

> She explained the risks **without sugar-coating them**.

她沒有**淡化風險**，而是直接說明。

MCQ-ready definition:

without sugar-coating X = 不刻意美化或淡化 X，而直接如實表達

12. **sugar-coated (figurative : 經美化的 ; 過分好聽的) — 粉飾過的 ; 糖衣包裝的**

Practice 1

> I don't want a **sugar-coated version** of what happened.

我不想聽一個**經過粉飾的版本**。

Practice 2

> The advertisement presents a **sugar-coated picture** of the job.

廣告把這份工作描繪成一幅**過度美化的景象**。

MCQ-ready definition:

sugar-coated = 被刻意包裝得較正面、較溫和或較容易接受的

13. **sugar-coated language — 粉飾性的說法 ; 好聽包裝**

Practice 1

> The report avoided **sugar-coated language**.

報告避免使用**粉飾性的說法**。

Practice 2

> His **sugar-coated language** hid how serious the problem was.

他那些**好聽的包裝說法**掩蓋了問題的嚴重程度。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****sugar-coated language = 刻意把負面事情描述得較溫和或正面的措辭****

14. ****sugar-coating (literal : 糖衣) — 糖衣****

Practice 1

> The tablet has a thin ****sugar coating****.

藥片外面有一層薄薄的****糖衣****。

Practice 2

> The ****sugar coating**** makes the medicine easier to swallow.

****糖衣****令藥物較容易吞服。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****sugar coating = 覆蓋在藥片、食物等表面的一層糖****

15. ****sugar-coating (figurative : 粉飾 ; 美化) — 粉飾 ; 好聽的包裝****

Practice 1

> I want the truth without the ****sugar-coating****.

我想聽真相，不需要那些****粉飾和好聽包裝****。

Practice 2

> The explanation contained too much ****sugar-coating****.

那個解釋有太多****美化成分****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****sugar-coating = 令不愉快的事實聽起來較好接受的美化或淡化處理****

16. ****sugar-coated pill — 糖衣藥丸 ; 包裝得較易接受的「苦藥」****

Literal and figurative.

Practice 1

> The child found the **sugar-coated pill** easier to swallow.

孩子覺得**糖衣藥丸**較容易吞下。

Practice 2

> The small bonus was a **sugar-coated pill** alongside the unpopular changes.

那筆小額獎金像一層**糖衣**，令那些不受歡迎的改變稍微容易接受一點。

MCQ-ready definition:

sugar-coated pill = literal 糖衣藥丸；figuratively 一件不愉快的事情被較吸引人的部分包裝，使人較容易接受

Important distinction 1: **sugar-coat vs soften**

soften

make wording less harsh.

sugar-coat

goes further: make something unpleasant sound **better than it really is**.

> She softened her criticism.

她把批評說得比較溫和。

> She sugar-coated the problem.

她把問題**粉飾得沒那麼嚴重**。

So **sugar-coat** often has a mildly negative implication that reality is being dressed up.

Important distinction 2: **sugar-coat vs downplay**

downplay

make something seem **less important or serious**.

sugar-coat

make something seem **more pleasant or acceptable**.

For example:

> He downplayed the mistake.

他淡化錯誤的嚴重性。

> He sugar-coated the mistake.

他把錯誤**包裝得比較好聽**。

They overlap strongly, but the metaphor differs.

Important distinction 3: **sugar-coat vs gloss over**

sugar-coat

make the unpleasant thing sound nicer.

gloss over

avoid discussing unpleasant details fully.

> sugar-coat a failure

> 美化失敗

> gloss over a failure

> 輕輕帶過失敗，不深入談

A person can do both at once.

Important distinction 4: **sugar-coat vs hide**

hide

keep information completely secret.

sugar-coat

the information may still be revealed, but it is ****presented in a more favorable way****.

So:

> sugar-coating ≠ necessarily lying or concealing everything

Important distinction 5: ****sugar-coat vs lie****

This distinction matters.

To ****sugar-coat**** something does ****not automatically mean to lie****.

Someone may tell the basic truth but:

- * choose nicer wording,
- * minimize the unpleasant parts,
- * emphasize positives,
- * avoid blunt language.

So it can involve distortion, but the word itself does not necessarily mean a factual falsehood.

Important distinction 6: ****sugar-coat vs euphemism****

****euphemism****

a milder expression replacing a harsher one.

****sugar-coat****

the broader act of making an unpleasant situation sound more acceptable.

For example:

> using a euphemism can be one way of sugar-coating something

but they are not identical.

Important distinction 7: ****sugar-coat vs be tactful****

be tactful

Speak sensitively to avoid unnecessary hurt.

sugar-coat

may imply excessive softening or presenting reality too positively.

This is an important nuance:

- > tactful ≠ dishonest

- > sugar-coating can suggest avoiding full bluntness

You can be honest and tactful without sugar-coating.

Important distinction 8: **sugar-coat vs make excuses**

This is particularly important in your passage.

Kevin:

- > did not **sugar-coat it**

- > did not **make weak excuses**

These are two different avoidance strategies.

sugar-coat it

make the mistake sound less bad.

make excuses

give reasons designed to reduce personal responsibility.

For example:

- > “I probably could have checked more carefully.”

- > could be sugar-coating if the reality was **I wrongly accused you publicly**.

- > “I was tired, so it wasn't really my fault.”

- > is making an excuse.

Kevin does neither.

Important distinction 9: **sugar-coat vs explain**

An **explanation** simply tells why something happened.

A **sugar-coated explanation** deliberately makes it sound less unpleasant.

So explaining your actions is not automatically making excuses or sugar-coating them.

Important distinction 10: **sugar-coat is normally transitive**

Common:

> sugar-coat **the truth**

> sugar-coat **the problem**

> sugar-coat **it**

The object is the unpleasant thing being made to sound nicer.

Important distinction 11: **literal and figurative senses share the same metaphor**

Literal:

> unpleasant/bitter medicine + sweet sugar coating

> → easier to swallow

Figurative:

> unpleasant truth + pleasant language

> → easier to accept

That gives us the central conceptual metaphor:

難吞的藥 → 加糖衣 → 容易吞

難聽的真相 → 加好聽包裝 → 容易接受

This is why English also naturally uses phrases such as:

> a hard truth to swallow

「難以接受的真相」

Important distinction 12: **sugar-coated vs sweet**

sweet

literally sugary or figuratively kind/pleasant.

sugar-coated

literally covered with sugar, or figuratively **made artificially more pleasant**.

The second often has a critical nuance that **sweet** does not.

Important distinction 13: **sugar-coated version**

> Give me the truth, not the sugar-coated version.

means:

告訴我真相，不要給我一個經過美化的版本。

It does not mean that every detail is false; rather, the presentation has been deliberately softened.

Family-extension note

Sugar-coat has a very clean semantic development:

1. **literal physical coating**

* sugar-coated tablet

* sugar-coated food

2. **figurative verbal/emotional coating**

* sugar-coat the truth

* sugar-coat bad news

* sugar-coat a mistake

The metaphor is:

sugar makes bitter medicine easier to swallow → pleasant wording makes an unpleasant truth easier to accept

From there we get:

3. **adjective**

- * sugar-coated version
- * sugar-coated language

4. **noun**

- * literal sugar coating
- * figurative sugar-coating

This family is therefore not enormously polysemous, but its literal → figurative transition is extremely useful and very productive.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
-----	-----	-----	
sugar-coat (literal)	裹上糖衣	cover with sugar	
sugar-coated tablet	糖衣藥片	literal coating	
sugar-coat (figurative)	粉飾；美化	make unpleasant truth nicer	
sugar-coat it	把事情說得較好聽	soften reality	
sugar-coat the truth	粉飾真相	make truth easier to accept	
sugar-coat the facts	美化 / 淡化事實	soften facts	
sugar-coat bad news	把壞消息說得較好聽	soften bad news	
sugar-coat a mistake	淡化 / 粉飾錯誤	minimize fault	
sugar-coat a failure	粉飾失敗	make failure sound better	
sugar-coat reality	美化現實	idealize reality	
Don't sugar-coat it	別粉飾了；有話直說	be direct	
no way to sugar-coat it	沒辦法說得好聽	reality is clearly bad	
without sugar-coating	不加粉飾地	directly/honestly	
sugar-coated (figurative)	經粉飾的	made artificially pleasant	
sugar-coated version	美化過的版本	softened account	
sugar-coated language	粉飾性的說法	pleasant packaging	
sugar coating (literal)	糖衣	sugary layer	
sugar-coating (figurative)	粉飾；好聽包裝	verbal softening	
sugar-coated pill	糖衣藥丸 / 糖衣包裝的苦藥	unpleasant thing made easier	

For your original sentence

> What I appreciated was that he did not try to **sugar-coat it** or make weak excuses.

Here:

sugar-coat it = 不把自己的錯誤包裝得比較好聽，也不故意淡化自己做錯事的嚴重性

Kevin could have said something vague like:

> “There was just a little misunderstanding.”

That could **sugar-coat** what actually happened.

Instead, he directly admitted:

> he had **jumped to conclusions**,
> stress had **got the better of him**,
> and he had **embarrassed the speaker in front of the group**.

So a natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 我很欣賞的一點是，他沒有試圖**粉飾自己的錯誤 / 把事情輕描淡寫**，也沒有找一些無力的藉口。

For this context, **「粉飾」** captures the metaphor most closely, while **「輕描淡寫」** captures the natural conversational effect especially well.